

OURA RING 4

It changed how I think about rest, not exercise

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I am a speedcuber. I wear a ring on my finger. These two facts are, occasionally, in conflict. But more on that later. Three weeks ago I started wearing the Oura Ring 4 on my left ring finger, and somewhere between the first sleep report and the third readiness score, I realised I had been thinking about health tracking completely wrong. I had been obsessed with the output: steps, calories, workout duration. The more interesting story, it turned out, was happening while I was doing absolutely nothing. While I was asleep.

First impressions

The ring arrives in a small, considered box alongside a magnetic charging puck and a USB-C cable. The puck is compact, grey in colour, and takes up almost no space on a night stand. Setup is straightforward. Download the app, tap the ring to your phone, done.

The hardware feels quietly premium. All-titanium construction, inside and out, with sensors that sit flush against your finger rather than pressing into it.

That said, the ring is noticeably thick. If you have never worn a ring

before, or are used to a slim band, it will feel a little foreign for the first few days. It is not uncomfortable exactly, just present in a way that takes some adjustment. By the end of the first week I had largely stopped noticing it.

For context, I use a Samsung Galaxy Watch 6 Classic as my daily driver. I like it. It does a lot. But I have never fully gotten used to wearing a watch all the time, and I almost never sleep with it on. The strap is not particularly breathable and in Mumbai's humidity, you start sweating faster than you would expect. Mid-workout, the watch sometimes feels like it needs to come off. The ring never once gave me that urge.

The sleep gap

I want to lead with the most important thing this ring did in three weeks of testing, because it is the argument the rest of this review builds around.

On one particular night, my Galaxy Watch logged my sleep at 5 hours 36 minutes. The Oura Ring logged 6 hours 45 minutes. That is over an hour of sleep the watch simply did not register. For a device that is supposed to tell you how recovered you are, that is not a rounding

error. It is a fundamentally different picture of your night.

Now, I can tell you which device was closer to the truth on that particular night because the watch's own app shows a straight hour of no data recorded around 1:30 am. I was asleep. I would know if I wasn't asleep. The watch just was not paying attention. Ring-based optical sensing has a stronger research track record for sleep staging than wrist-based tracking regardless, largely because the finger has cleaner blood flow signal and is less prone to movement artefacts. But on this night the case made itself. The ring was there. The watch was not.

The practical consequence of this matters more than the spec difference. A health tracker that gives you incomplete sleep data is giving you a distorted readiness score every morning. You are making decisions about how hard to push in a workout, or whether to have that third coffee, based on numbers that do not reflect what your body went through. The ring fixed that. It also got me in the habit of trying to get a better score which caused me to be the most well-rested I have been in a long time